



Tracks on the ground

The movement of US Army M1A2 Abrams tanks such as this to an allied nation such as South Korea is an overt way of one country showing military and political support for another.

SHOW OF STRENGTH

While the tank has obvious tactical capabilities—as can be seen by the firing of its powerful 120 mm gun—the movement of such tanks is also a classic symbol of power projection in world politics, as well as being a source of reassurance to the allied or friendly nation. Despite the fact that many other more powerful, advanced, or expensive

military assets may have also been deployed for a joint exercise such as this, it is often the tanks that will be photographed and featured in the media coverage of the events. The tank is such a distinctive, large, and powerful weapon—or is seen as such by the general public—that it is often the symbolic piece of military equipment most seen to represent a nation's military supremacy and geopolitical strength.

An M1A2 Abrams fires on a range at Pocheon, South Korea, during a joint South Korean and US Army exercise in 2011.